

> **"BHARAT JODO YATRA IS A JOKE... CONGRESS A FLOP PARTY... I.N.D.I.A. IS BROKEN. A NATIONAL PARTY SHOULD BE ACCOMMODATIVE, CARRY PEOPLE, HAVE CHARACTER. CONGRESS LACKS ALL OF THESE"**

Q. The Congress calls you the BJP's B-team. It says that's why the ED has gone silent in its cases against your daughter K. Kavitha.
That is a cock and bull case, 100 per cent vindictive by the BJP, we will fight it in court. It is the liquor policy of Delhi, done openly, open to all. They changed the policy to get more income for the state. Where is the scam in it? It is [a] created [case] against [Arvind] Kejriwal and my daughter. I don't have any truck with the BJP. I'm expanding my party to the national level.

Q. The Congress says KCR betrayed Sonia Gandhi as you had said you'd merge your party if they agreed to form Telangana.
In fact, Sonia Gandhi betrayed us. There was a long process and, for a while, I was with the UPA. But they backtracked on their promise of forming a state after they came to power in the first term in 2004. Then, in 2009, when I went on a hunger strike, the UPA agreed. By then, Andhra Pradesh CM [Y.S.] Rajasekhara Reddy had died in an accident and his son [current CM Jagan Mohan] was revolting against the Congress. They thought Telangana would go too, so they changed their mind. With great difficulty, we got the bill passed in the Lok Sabha in February 2014 when the UPA was still in power.

Q. What happened after that?
Then, I met Madam Gandhi and told her: thanks, better late than never. She asked about elections, and I told her we are willing to merge the party if she gives my party more MLA tickets and the leadership. She agreed and said she would discuss it with her party. But the next day, Digvijaya Singh called me and, in our discussions, said seat distribution would be done according to Congress norms and the state leadership would be decided after elections. They wanted us to play second fiddle. So, my party conducted a survey, which revealed we will get more than 50 seats—it was clear we had the majority. Luckily, people gave us the full mandate and we came to power. So, where is the question of us cheating the Congress?

Q. You had once called Rahul Gandhi a buffoon. Has your opinion of him changed after his Bharat Jodo Yatra?
Bharat Jodo Yatra is also a big joke, what is the *sandesh* (message)? There was some filmy dialogue on *mohabbat*. What about poverty in the country and unemployment?

Q. You renamed your party Bharat Rashtra Samithi and wanted to form a third front that was non-BJP and non-Congress. Why non-Congress?
Congress is a flop party. They developed the habit of winning elections by default. It is an arrogant party that has no system, and whose policy differs from state to state. They go to Karnataka and say something, go to Telangana say something else and go to Rajasthan and say another thing. When you proclaim yourself to be a national party, you need character, but it is lacking in it.

Q. What is your opinion of INDIA, the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance?
They are broken now. Akhilesh Yadav is out of it, Nitish Kumar is scolding them every day. The Congress does not want to accommodate people. A national party should be accommodative, carry people along.

Q. Your slogan is from Good to Great. What are your plans for the third term?
We are good now, but we will try to attain excellence—that is our quest, one that will never end. But if you keep trying, you get dividends beyond expectations. There may be some failures, but ultimately you will get the result. In the third term, we will focus on health and education because we are far more settled economically now.

Q. Will you continue as CM if your party wins a third term?
As a matter of fact, I need to contribute to the country now. Not go to the Centre but sit here and do it. In Maharashtra, our party has made a beginning with excellent results in the gram panchayat polls. About 2.5 million people have joined the BRS in Maharashtra. That's a big surprise to one and all in the country.

Q. What is the KCR model of development?
In a country like India, we require a mixed path. There should be welfare for the poor and the needy, and agriculture should not be neglected under any circumstances. Simultaneously, we should go for industry. Other aspects depend from state to state. India is such a blessed country. Unlike other countries, like the USA or China, we have so much cultivable land. We have so much solar incidence, which is best for growing crops. We have a huge population, so there is no shortage of labour. We have water that is far in excess of our requirement. Bring all three together, and we can capture the world food market. I believe the next government at the Centre in 2024 should be a government of the farmers. *Ab ki baar, kisan sarkar.* ■